

# inform

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# Optimism despite uncertainty.

Dear readers

The year 2025 brought us solid results. Our PET and PAC divisions continued to perform well, demonstrating that our core business rests on a stable foundation. Things are progressing encouragingly at our subsidiary, Otto Systems, which develops and sells complete turnkey PET preform production solutions. And the MED division is making progress in its demanding market sector, too.

That said, the current economic environment is presenting all of us with real challenges. For Otto Hofstetter AG, a company that manufactures 100 percent of its products in Switzerland for export, we are particularly exposed to the unsettled global situation. The strong Swiss franc is hurting our competitiveness internationally, and the tariffs imposed by the US are significantly affecting key sales markets. Geopolitical tensions have created trade barriers that are making some markets more difficult to access or even closing them off entirely, including some where we have worked closely with customers for many years. This environment necessitates the continuous review of our strategy, with special attention paid to new opportunities as they arise. The current moment demands entrepreneurial agility, perseverance and the confidence continually to find new paths and solutions.



Given these challenges, it is all the more important to nurture the things that are within our control. The quality of our products and services remains paramount. Our performance must continually renew the trust of our customers. The sustainability of our products and processes is another of our firm commitments as a company. The corporate carbon footprint report, published earlier this year, is an important milestone in this effort. It captures the current state of the environmental footprint of our products and our company and points the way for targeted optimisations.

Ultimately, what sustains us through these challenging times are the people behind this company: a motivated team in Uznach, loyal customers worldwide, and partners we can rely on. To all of you, I extend my sincere thanks. In this issue of "inform", some of our people share their thoughts and insights. I hope you find this issue rewarding and I look forward to meeting you in person in the coming weeks and months.

Sincerely, Sascha Bigler

## Imprint.

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A portrait of Jakub Rozwandowicz, a man with short brown hair, a beard, and glasses, wearing a light grey blazer over a dark blue shirt. He is looking slightly to the right. In the background, there is a large, stylized white logo on a dark background. The logo consists of a circle with a vertical line through it, and a horizontal line that forms a cross-like shape. The text "Step by step." is overlaid in large, bold, blue letters.

# Step by step.

Located in central **Poland**, PET preform maker **Mlynex** produces around **50 million PET preforms** per month. The company was founded by Florian Cander and is now run by his son, Jakub. In this interview, **Jakub Rozwandowicz** explains how a water-powered flour mill became a modern preform manufacturer, why **flexibility is their strongest selling point** in the Polish market, and what the collaboration with **Otto Hofstetter AG** means for Mlynex's growth.



It began in 2000 with the purchase of a used system. Since then, Mlynex's output has grown steadily to its current level of 50 million preforms per month.

**Let's start by taking a look back at the early years of your company. What were the first products in your portfolio?**

The name Mlynex reveals a lot about our roots. "Mlyn" is the Polish word for mill, and that's exactly what my father, Florian, started with. He produced flour, powered by a stream-driven waterwheel. The business was challenging, and after a few years he decided to switch to plastics processing. He initially entered the bottle production business, purchasing preforms and blowing bottles himself. He soon realised that he could also manufacture the preforms. So, he bought a used BMB machine, built in 1992. That was the real starting point for what Mlynex is today. He never changed the name because the mill's history is part of our story.

**Can you highlight the most significant milestones in the company's history?**

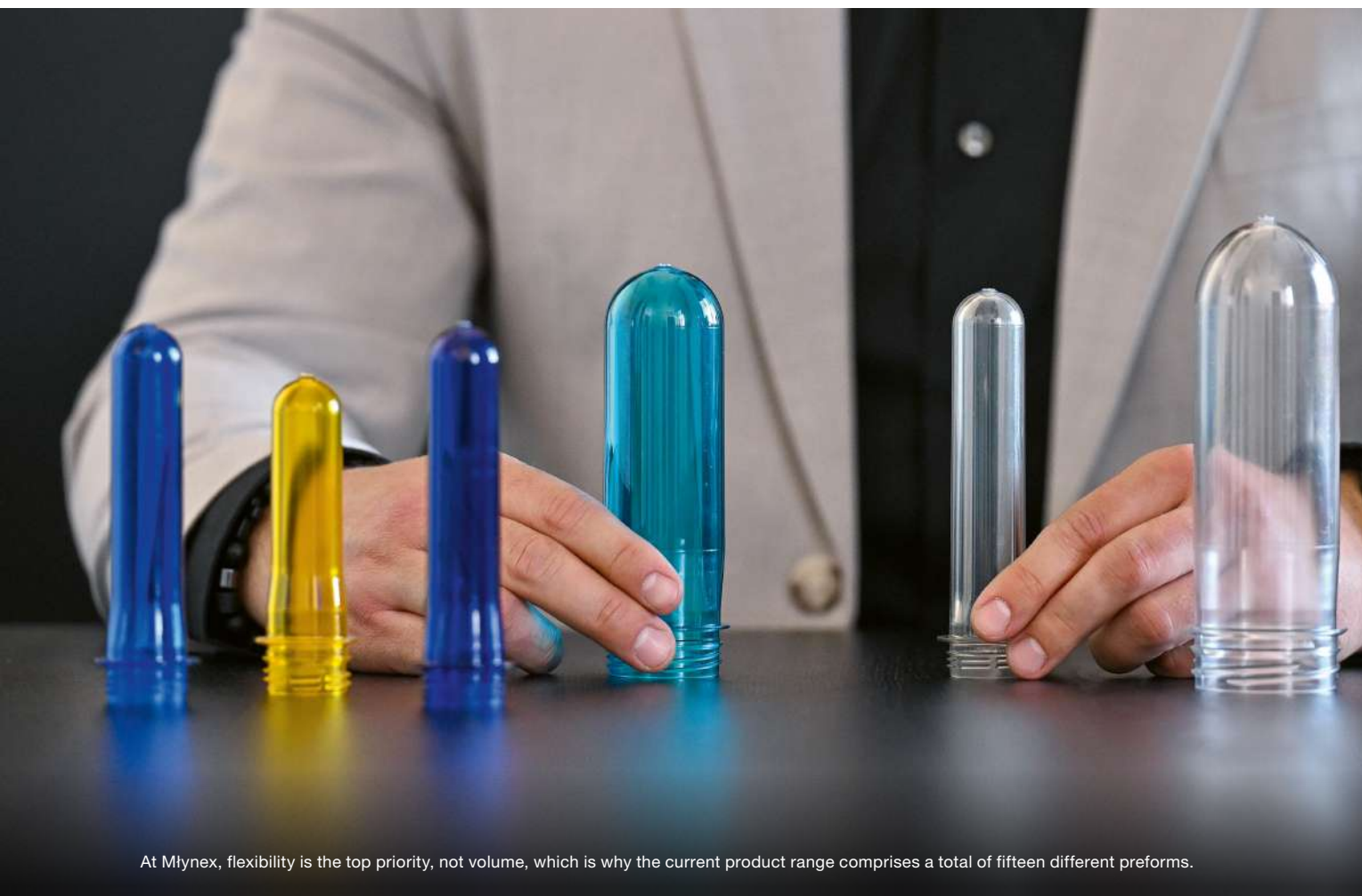
The purchase of that first injection moulding machine certainly counts. Back then, we knew very little about the technology. The first three or four years were very difficult. Sometimes we would produce for a week, then the machines would sit idle because we lacked new orders. Step by step, we learned the technical side of things and, at the same time, acquired new customers. Another leap forward came when my father was

able to purchase four used machines from a Polish company that was going out of business. This significantly increased our capacity. In 2021, we then commissioned our first system from Otto Systems: a 96-cavity line with the BMB eKW320 and a Yudo robot. That was another big step for us.

**How would you describe the company's structure today, with its various business units?**

We are a small, family-run company. My father has overall responsibility and makes the key decisions. I manage the operational side of the business, including customer relations, new projects, material procurement, sales, and logistics. There are six of us in the office, and the production team consists of 17 employees, including system operators, mechanics, and warehouse staff, as well as a production manager and an employee who focuses exclusively on quality control. Our company structure also adheres to the requirements of the BRCGS Packaging Materials Standard, which we have implemented. This provides security both for us and our customers.

**With a monthly output of around 50 million preforms, you are a significant producer. How does your position help you within the overall Polish market?**



At Młynex, flexibility is the top priority, not volume, which is why the current product range comprises a total of fifteen different preforms.

We don't see ourselves as a high-volume supplier competing with the largest companies on unit prices. Our strength lies in our flexibility. In Poland, there are many small and medium-sized bottlers who need custom bottles and the corresponding preforms in smaller quantities. We are the right partner for these customers. We also produce special colours and short runs. WIP, for example, is a much larger Polish company that we look to for guidance. But we are growing steadily and want to compete with the best.

#### What are the current PET industry trends in Poland?

The PET industry is under considerable pressure regarding sustainability and environmental responsibility. Large customers like Lidl and Aldi already require around 30 percent recycled material in the preforms. We are prepared for this. At the same time, we see a clear trend toward lighter preforms while maintaining the same strength. We are achieving this target together with our customers, especially with new neck geometries. And customisation is also

a growing trend. More and more bottlers are looking for their own distinctive bottle shapes, which plays to our strengths as a flexible production partner.

#### You produce a range of 0.3- to 10-litre preforms. How has the demand for different neck standards, such as 28 mm,

38 mm or the new 26 mm neck, developed in recent years?

We currently offer five neck standards: PCO 28 1881, PCO 28 1810, Bericap 38-33, Bericap 48-40, and the new 26 mm neck, GME.30.37. We deliberately chose to keep the 1810 neck in our product range because many smaller

customers still require it. We introduced the 26 mm neck in 2021 with our new production line. In total, we cover more than 15 products.

#### How are you dealing with the general shortage of skilled workers in Poland, and how do you find qualified staff for

**"WE DON'T SEE OURSELVES AS A HIGH-VOLUME SUPPLIER COMPETING WITH THE LARGEST COMPANIES ON UNIT PRICES. OUR STRENGTH LIES IN OUR FLEXIBILITY."**

Jakub Rozwandowicz, General Director of Młynex

### your production?

This is a real challenge, as it is everywhere in the world. The younger generation is more drawn to IT and social media. We can still find enough people for production positions in our region; Polish youngsters aren't afraid of this work. For specialised engineers, we go directly to the Łódź University of Technology, which is nearby. We invite students to work with us and see if a long-term collaboration develops. We have found that once someone starts with us, they usually stay. Our employee turnover is low.

### How important is in-house training of junior staff to ensure your quality standards are maintained in the long term?

Very important. We focus on learning by doing. A new technician starts as an assistant and works alongside experienced colleagues. They grow into their role gradually. In the coming years, I would like to send our mould technicians to Uznach for targeted training directly at Otto Hofstetter AG. We want our people to know the moulds inside and out so they understand what they can do and what they absolutely must not do. We believe this is an investment that will pay off in the long run.

### What makes Mlynex particularly attractive as an employer in your region of Zduńska Wola?

We create a family-like atmosphere where everyone feels like a valued part of the team. My father and I know all the employees personally and we regularly visit the production area to talk to them. Anyone with a problem can talk directly to us. People appreciate that. Job security and a good working environment are very important to many people these days.

### To what extent is rPET already being used in your production, and how do you see its future development?

We're not yet a major player in the circular economy, but we're preparing to become one. Today, we can already offer our customers preforms with around 30 percent rPET. Larger customers are actively requesting it; smaller ones not yet. But the proportion will grow, and we want to be ready when that demand arises.

### Are high energy costs a challenge for you, and how do you ensure economical production?

By far the biggest cost factor in a preform is the material, around 80 percent. Regarding energy costs, we've already

undertaken some actions. We've installed solar panels on all the roofs of our plant. In addition, we purchase electricity on the Polish spot market, which allows us to secure more favourable terms. Poland's energy prices are not comparable to those of Germany or France. With our own solar power generation, we can improve the situation even further.

### You use hybrid production systems sourced from Italy and moulds from Switzerland. What factors determine the quality of such a complete system for you?

For us, the combination of a reliable machine and a precise mould is crucial. We work exclusively with machines from BMB and moulds from Otto Hofstetter AG. This combination gives us the process reliability we need to deliver consistently high quality. We are very satisfied with this system and we closely follow the new solutions our two partners are developing.

**"WE KNOW THAT OTTO  
HOFSTETTER AG WILL STILL BE  
AROUND IN 30 OR 40 YEARS  
BECAUSE THE NEXT GENERATION  
IS ALREADY GETTING INVOLVED."**

Jakub Rozwandowicz, General Director of Mlynex

### Why did you decide to collaborate with Otto Hofstetter AG back in 2014?

The recommendation came from WIP, our then-supplier of used machines and a long-standing customer of Otto Hofstetter AG. WIP told us they were the best that Europe had to offer in mould-making. We trusted their assessment and followed their lead. It was the right decision. Since then, we have worked exclusively with moulds from Uznach.

### How important is it that your mould partner is also a family business?

You can feel it, and it's important. We operate with similar values, even though Otto Hofstetter AG is on a completely different scale. And we know that Otto Hofstetter AG will still be around in 30 or 40 years because the next generation is already getting involved. I've already met Lea Hofstetter. It's important to have a face, you know each other personally. That's what we understand by a partnership.

### At Otto Hofstetter AG, Albert Weber has been your contact for over ten years. What significance does this long-term personal relationship have for the development of your company?

For me, Albert is like a second father in business, along with my own father. If I have a problem, I send him a message, and he always replies. He finds solutions, even for unusual requirements, and remains open and uncomplicated. I'm very



Process reliability and consistent high quality are top priorities for Mlynex, which is why they rely on experts from BMB and Otto Hofstetter AG.



In Poland, there are many small and medium-sized bottlers who demand bottles in a wide variety of shapes and colours.



Mlynex feels a strong responsibility towards its customers, which is why quality control is very rigorous.

glad that we have this collaboration. Otto Hofstetter AG is an impressive company, and Albert is our anchor.

**"OTTO HOFSTETTER AG IS  
AN IMPRESSIVE COMPANY,  
AND ALBERT WEBER  
IS OUR ANCHOR."**

Jakub Rozwandowicz, General Director of Mlynex

**Where do you see Mlynex in five to seven years, and what role will the planned modernisations of your existing plants play in that?**

I have big dreams. A new building, new lines, more capacity, even more solar energy. But I think sequentially, in steps. This year and next are what count. We are going through difficult times right now, in the world and also in Poland. The next step is replacing our existing MC 350 plant with new, efficient production systems from Otto Systems. That's happening, and that's our focus right now. My daughter Viktoria is growing up; she's smart and tech-savvy. Perhaps she'll join us in a few years. The third generation is getting ready.



MŁYNEX

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Founded: 2000  
Specialist in: PET preforms in 15 sizes, custom colours and smaller volumes  
Industries: beverages and drinking water

Janiszewice 3C, 98-200 Zduńska Wola, Poland

# Thinking backwards.

With innovative, digitalised **reverse engineering**, Otto Hofstetter AG is expanding its range of services for PET preform producers. Collaborating with **Northern Ireland's BMT**, preform designs for new bottles can now be prototyped much more quickly and efficiently, and **existing bottle designs can also be significantly optimised**. Reduced development risks and costs, improved process reliability and radically shortened times from concept to series production are some key benefits for PET producers.

### Thinking from the bottle's perspective.

In the PET industry, usually a finished bottle has served as the starting point for defining the geometry of a preform. But today's challenges grow ever more complex, often involving new materials, stricter environmental requirements and ever-increasing cost pressures. A new approach is needed and AI-enhanced digital prototyping and optimising offer many advantages.

A precise 3D drawing of the desired container provides an excellent starting point for design optimisations. The volume, weight and geometries of the shoulder and base are the basis for the reverse engineering calculations. Since the bottleneck dimensions remain unchanged during the stretch blow moulding process, it serves as the starting point for the preform's mouth geometry. Taking the biaxial stretch ratio into account – typically a factor of eight – the preform's length, diameter and wall thickness can then be calculated.

### Simulation instead of trial and error.

The biggest challenge in reverse engineering is understanding the entire stretch blow moulding process. The stretch ratio,

processing temperatures, blowing pressures and cooling all significantly influence the result. Blow Moulding Technologies (BMT) employs digital simulation instead of producing a costly, time-consuming test series. Using its proprietary BLOWSCAN and THERMOSCAN technologies, BMT captures real material behavioural data under production conditions. BMT's THERMOSCAN system measures the internal and external temperature distribution within the preform with a precision of 0.5 °C.

The captured data is then incorporated into an AI-supported simulation that models the expected material behaviour with an accuracy of up to 95 percent. This allows the wall thickness distribution, compression strength and burst pressure of the bottle to be virtually validated even before the tooling is designed. Changes to the design or the process can initially be tested digitally, minimising the use of costly prototypes.

### rPET's unique challenges.

Using mechanically recycled rPET poses real technical challenges for manufacturers that can only be partially overcome with conventional methods. Due to thermal degradation, rPET has a significantly narrower processing window than virgin material. Without precise control, there is a risk of pearlescence, a milky haze also known as stress whitening, which degrades bottle quality. BMT's combined method of digital simulation and material characteristics allows the properties of rPET batches to be precisely modelled. This, in turn, enables the precise adjustment of stretch rates and temperatures.

### Every gram saved counts.

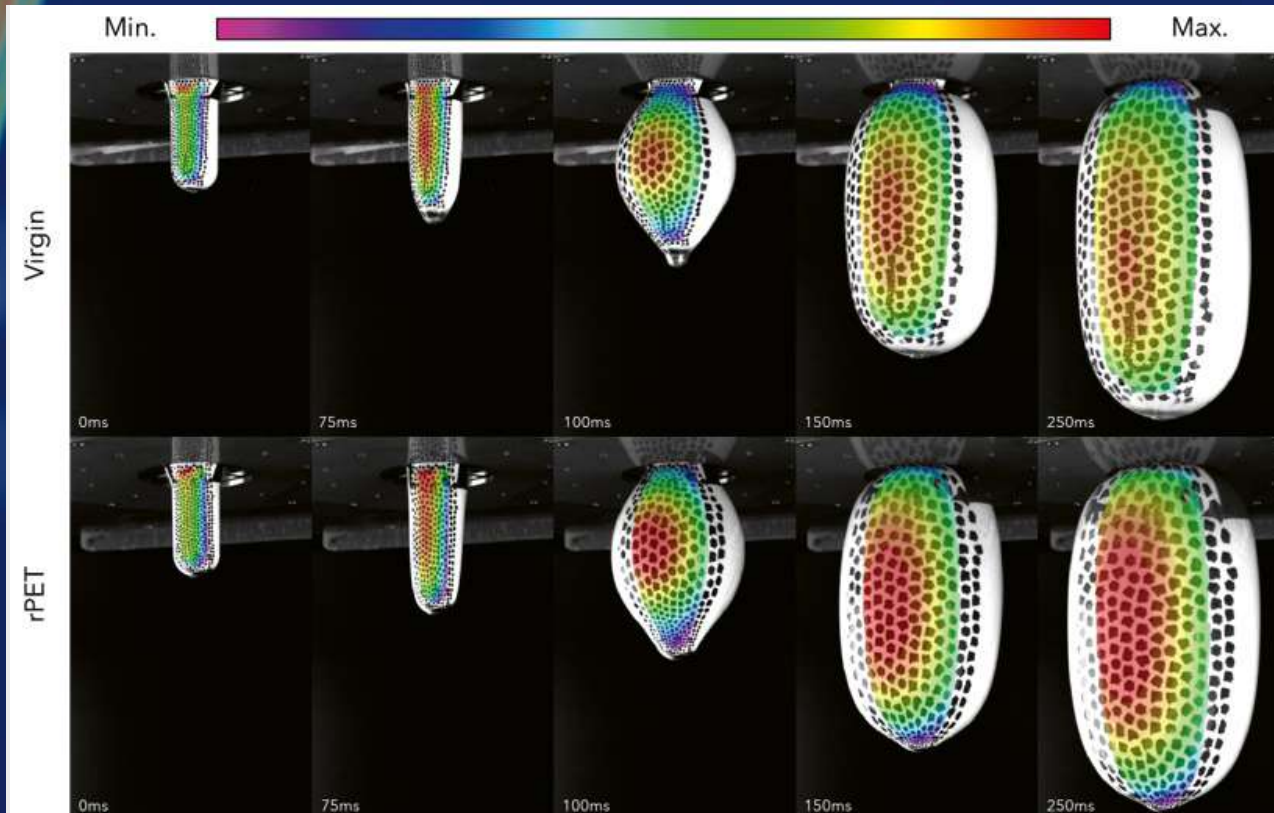
Materials account for approximately 70 percent of the cost of preforms. In case studies, BMT achieved a 13 percent weight reduction with a 20.7-gram preform without compromising the packaging's characteristics. Apply this weight reduction to an output of 25 million bottles per year and it amounts to a saving of over 65 tons of plastic, which significantly affects the CO<sub>2</sub> balance while reducing material costs. By adapting specific insert components, this kind of savings can also be realised with existing moulds.

### Fewer process interfaces.

When the mouldmaker performs this reverse engineering themselves, the design and tooling are perfectly aligned from the outset. Otto Hofstetter AG, in collaboration with BMT, coordinates all the steps, from bottle analysis and simulation to preform concept development, tooling, bottle or preform sampling, right through to series production release. This full-service approach relieves the PET producer of the burden of coordinating and aligning the various partners. Furthermore,



Digital simulations and virtual testing assess and help optimise the preform process.



High-speed cameras record the entire blow-moulding process and highlight any areas of stress in colour.

the process is independent of specific blow moulding machine manufacturers, allowing customers complete freedom in implementing individual designs. According to BMT's experience, development times and overall costs for a preform are reduced by 30 to 50 percent. Through reduced scrap and lower material consumption, an investment in this form of reverse engineering often pays for itself within just a few months.

#### Supported every step of the way.

Reverse engineering integrates seamlessly into Otto Hofstetter AG's comprehensive service portfolio. The Swiss mould specialists recommend incorporating their expertise as early as the conceptual phase. This could involve optimising the design of existing solutions for greater quality and more efficient material usage, with rigorous blow mould testing to ensure complete machine compatibility. Otto Hofstetter AG also builds pilot moulds with two to sixteen cavities in order to test preforms under realistic conditions using the customer's original granulate. Small quantities of bottles can also be blown for testing purposes upon request.

Once all inspections and tests are successfully completed, the optimised production mould is manufactured, tested and delivered, along with complete documentation. Regular maintenance checks, performance optimisations and upgrade op-

tions are available throughout the mould's entire service life.

Further production support comes from the OH-Xchange programme, which dramatically cuts downtime for the replacement of hot runners to two days instead of twenty. And Otto Hofstetter AG's Second-Life platform supports secure buying and selling of refurbished, warranted high-precision moulds.

All in all, in an increasingly challenging market environment, Otto Hofstetter AG constantly strives to help PET producers succeed, taking advantage of proven innovations to improve efficiency, cut costs and enhance quality.



For more information about BMT:  
[www.bmt-ni.com](http://www.bmt-ni.com)

# A small diamond.

SAF Bianco was founded in 1945 in Schio, northern Italy. Today it produces plastic packaging for the food industry. Managing director Massimiliano Bianco is the third generation to lead this family-run business. We recently had a conversation with his son, Emanuele, who joined the company almost a year ago. We talked about growth, innovation, generational change and what sustainability really means in the packaging industry.



**In a previous interview, in 2016, your father said he wanted to grow slowly. First in terms of products, then customers, then in terms of business areas. How far has SAF Bianco come along this path?**

Emanuele Bianco: SAF Bianco is a completely different company today from what it was in 2016.

Our production, warehousing, offices, even the exterior colour of the building, have all changed.

And we haven't just grown with the Italian market, but have also expanded internationally into Switzerland, Germany and the Czech Republic. We even export to the USA. But the most important things have not changed: our mindset, our values, and the way we treat customers and employees. These things are in the Bianco family's DNA, and that doesn't change.

**In 2016, SAF Bianco employed 37 people and produced around 350 million packages a year. Where does the company stand today?**

We've grown by about two percent annually and now produce approximately 425 million units a year. We employ 34

permanent people, plus about 20 more between on-call staff and external specialists in sales, design, and legal – a total of 50 to 55 people. If you include the new sister company for thermoforming, that adds another 15 people and 200 to 250 million units per year. We were also able to acquire the building

next to our existing plant and set up a new, semi-automated warehouse. This move will enable us to double our production capacity compared to two years ago.

**So, your father has added a second technology. What's behind this decision?**

Our goal is to serve the food

industry as a packaging group, regardless of the material or technology that is called for. Every technology has its advantages and disadvantages. Some are cheaper and more productive while others offer higher quality and flexibility in design. What's best for the customer depends on their specific needs. With injection moulding and thermoforming, we can now meet more customer needs than ever before.

**"OUR MINDSET, OUR VALUES,  
AND THE WAY WE TREAT  
CUSTOMERS AND EMPLOYEES.  
THESE THINGS ARE IN THE  
BIANCO FAMILY'S DNA,  
AND THAT DOESN'T CHANGE."**

Emanuele Bianco, R&D at SAF Bianco

### When did you join the company, and what is your role today?

I joined SAF almost a year ago. After completing my bachelor's degree in engineering in Milan, I gained experience in strategic consulting in Singapore. Later, while finishing my master's, I joined a special programme at Otto Hofstetter AG in Switzerland to deepen my understanding of the technical aspects of injection moulding.

Today, I work in SAF's research and development department, not only because innovation is my passion, but also because it has been the focus of my most recent studies. I also spend time in the production department, learning more about moulds and machines, and I closely follow my father across a wide range of activities, from legal matters and strategic investments to procurement and customer meetings. It's about understanding the company from the ground up, with the goal of being ready to lead it one day.

**In 2016, your father said the third generation was still too young even to think about the fourth generation joining.**

### What has changed since then?

Perhaps we've all grown up a bit. No, seriously: the passion for packaging and the connection to my family's business have always been there. From an early age, I could see myself continuing the legacy of a family that has been in this industry for over 80 years. Today, I can see that my father and his cousins are

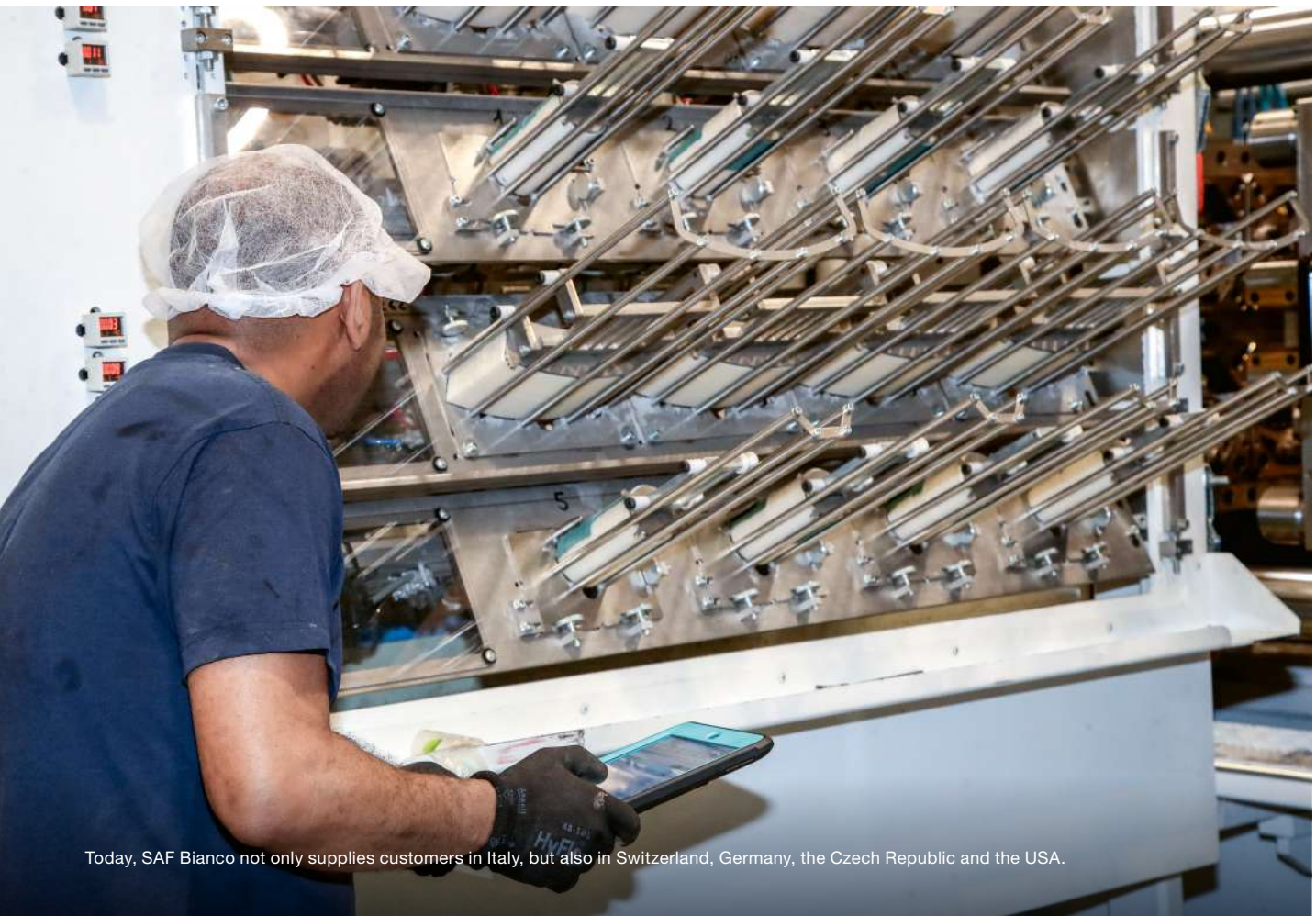
happy to know that someone carrying their surname may one day take over the company, as that's not something to take for granted nowadays. In the end, they're not simply handing over a business, they're entrusting responsibility towards the employees, towards the customers, and towards the region.

**"WHAT WE NEED IS NOT  
A LINEAR ECONOMY WITH THE  
LOWEST POSSIBLE IMPACT,  
BUT A FUNCTIONING  
CIRCULAR ECONOMY."**

*Emanuele Bianco, Innovation Manager at SAF Bianco*

### What does innovation mean to you?

For me, innovation isn't a narrowly defined term. It can take many forms: the launch of a new product, or a programme that improves working conditions for our employees, or even the establishment of a school partnership to educate younger generations on how plastics should be used responsibly. The crucial point is that innovation doesn't necessarily have to be something entirely new to the world. You can also combine



Today, SAF Bianco not only supplies customers in Italy, but also in Switzerland, Germany, the Czech Republic and the USA.



Massimiliano Bianco, the third generation of his family to lead the company, has laid a solid foundation to meet future challenges.

ideas and approaches from other industries to create something meaningful for SAF Bianco.

Previously, in product design, everything was created by hand and prototypes were built out of wood. Today, we work with software and 3D technologies. Customers will soon be able to see their product realistically on the shelf, using VR technologies, adjusting dimensions and decorations without having to wait weeks for a physical prototype. This has already transformed our product development process. Who knows what's coming next? I'm excited to be part of it.

**Let's talk about sustainability. In 2016, your father spoke of his plans for biodegradable materials. Have these plans been implemented? At the same time, the latest EU Packaging Directive sets ambitious targets for 2030. What does that mean specifically for SAF Bianco?**

I have to say that we've had to revise that earlier assessment. At the time, there was a great deal of uncertainty surrounding biodegradable materials. Today, we know that they are not the right answer for food packaging. What we need is not a linear economy with the lowest possible impact, but a functioning circular economy. As converters, our role is to develop products that are easier to recycle, use less material, and require less energy to produce.

With respect to the new EU regulations, I consider myself particularly fortunate. My father started embracing the principles of PPWR over 20 years ago, driven by strong business intuition – an approach that today clearly sets us apart from the competition, with a product portfolio that is already largely compliant with the new requirements. This has only been possible thanks to the ecosystem of partners we have built over time – partners capable of providing the most advanced and



Family-owned, SAF Bianco communicates transparently, not only about its carbon footprint but also about its social and ethical responsibilities.

efficient technologies available on the market. Otto Hofstetter AG is a key part of this equation, enabling us to operate at the highest level of efficiency with some of the most advanced moulds in the industry.

**SAF Bianco is ISCC-PLUS certified, among other certifications, and has published a sustainability report since 2022. What changes has this process brought internally?**

It has forced us to take a closer look at all aspects of the business. Today, we measure our corporate carbon footprint and produce ESG reports. We invest heavily in energy efficiency and we recently installed solar panels. What's more, the Bolli-no Etico Sociale (Social Ethical Certificate) that we carry certifies that we also care about our employees and the region. We support sports clubs, schools and social projects, including two villages in Africa that we provide with access to clean water. In addition, we are implementing a new employee benefits programme that includes health insurance and subsidies for energy and food costs. Anyone who works a third of their day for our company de-

serves support that goes beyond their wages. The impact of our commitment to our employees is reflected in our low employee turnover: when someone leaves the company, it's usually because they're retiring.

**How has the competitive landscape in your segment developed?**

The Italian market is one of the most demanding in Europe.

It was back in 2016, it is today, and it will continue to be in future. There are many players offering a wide range of products, backed by years of experience in the industry. In this context, SAF competes with a disruptive approach. We invest in the most advanced technologies

available and consistently aim to excel in efficiency, reliability and product quality.

Competition is also intensifying today as there is growing pressure from alternative materials such as paper. Nowadays, packaging-related decisions can be driven by marketing considerations, and newer generations are not always fully aware

**"I STRONGLY BELIEVE IN MY FATHER'S PHILOSOPHY OF PREFERRING A SMALL DIAMOND TO A BIG ROCK."**

Emanuele Bianco, R&D at SAF Bianco

"ANYONE WHO WORKS A THIRD OF THEIR TIME FOR OUR COMPANY DESERVES SUPPORT THAT GOES BEYOND JUST THEIR SALARY."

Emanuele Bianco, R&D at SAF Bianco

of the role plastics can play within a well-functioning circular economy. Polymers have shaped modern society, and they remain the most effective materials in protecting food and reducing waste. For this reason, SAF has also evolved towards a more consultancy-oriented approach: we not only help our customers with designing tailored solutions that are both appealing and efficient, but we also guide them in making truly sustainable and compliant choices. This positioning clearly sets us apart from our competitors, allowing us to excel particularly in specialised market segments, where leading F&B players want to be served by forward-looking and reliable partners.

**In 2016, your father said that a handshake, a phone call or an email was all it took to get things started with Otto Hofstetter AG. How has this partnership developed since then?**

The most important component has always remained the same: trust. What has changed is the intensity of the collaboration. Today, we purchase more moulds, the projects are more complex, and the communication has become even closer. Fabio Crestani at Otto Hofstetter AG is an essential contact for us. He knows our production, our requirements and our history. This isn't the typical customer-supplier relationship, it's a long-lasting partnership where both parties have evolved

together. However, the dependence on a single person also carries a risk if that person is unavailable. That's something we consider.

**For you personally, this partnership has been a given from the very beginning. How do you experience the collaboration? What would you like to see more of from Otto Hofstetter AG?**

As a matter of course, I experience working with Otto Hofstetter AG in the most positive ways. What impresses me is the combination of technical expertise and personal commitment. That's not the case everywhere in this industry. To be honest, what I'd like to see in future is more exchange about new processes. Injection compression moulding is a technology that some European competitors are already experimenting with. That's an area where I'd like to see more input from Otto Hofstetter.

**Looking ahead to the next ten years, how do you think SAF Bianco will be positioned then?**

I hope SAF Bianco will be bigger, but I want that to happen without losing our identity or vision. I strongly believe in my father's philosophy of preferring a small diamond to a big rock. I've always admired his passion for this business and his willingness to give it everything. Today, he is giving me the space to build a young team, experiment, and learn from mistakes. Together, our goal is to grow steadily and organically, evolving into a packaging group capable of serving a wide range of customers in the food industry. At the core, however, nothing changes: we want to keep supporting our customers in delivering food safely into people's homes. It's a noble mission that I deeply embrace, one I'm committed to carrying forward to make both my father and our family proud.



SAF Bianco SRL  
www.safbianco.it, info@safbianco.it

Founded: 1945  
Specialist in: Plastic containers and lids for the food and beverages industry  
Industries: Food industry and FMCG

Via Lago di Misurina, 30, 36015 Schio (Vicenza), Italy

# Shrinking the footprint.

Otto Hofstetter AG recently published its first-ever **corporate carbon footprint**, a report that calculates the total amount of greenhouse gas emissions caused directly and indirectly by our activities. One source of emissions stood out and we are **taking steps to reduce this hotspot**. We are introducing new steel grades that will substantially reduce **CO<sub>2</sub> emissions** without compromising the **quality and durability of our moulds**, or increasing their cost.

The corporate carbon footprint (CCF) analysis was conducted in collaboration with the Swiss consulting firm Neosys AG, adhering to standard measurement practices established by the Greenhouse Gas Protocol as well as recognised Swiss and other international emission criteria. The CCF, performed at the company's headquarters in Uznach, Switzerland, uses verified data from 2024. With this corporate carbon footprint, Otto Hofstetter AG establishes a transparent benchmark for its future ESG- and CSRD-oriented reports. Furthermore, the CCF provides reliable data for customers and partners when they are required to provide emissions data for their supply chains. In Europe, such regulatory reporting and transparency requirements are steadily increasing.

### The data at a glance

For the business year 2024, Otto Hofstetter AG produced a total of approximately 137,600 metric tons of CO<sub>2</sub> equivalents. Of this total, less than one percent is attributable to direct emissions and purchased energy, and around four percent to upstream activities such as material procurement and logistics. The remaining 95 percent is attributed to the twelve-year usage period of the moulds. This high weighting results directly from the moulds' designs, which are optimised for long service lives and high availability. In short, our moulds are used intensively and for many years. In the CCF accounting system, emissions from a product's future usage are fully attributed to the manufacturer.

### Customer challenges

By purchasing a mould, customers automatically incorporate its ecological footprint into their own CCF balance sheet. This "CO<sub>2</sub> backpack" is gaining importance in the European context. First, the price in the EU Emissions Trading System has been around 70 to 100 euros per ton of CO<sub>2</sub> for some time now, and second, the demands for transparency along the supply chain are increasing. This has implications for reporting and influences customers' investment decisions. Otto Hofstetter AG takes this challenge seriously and has made its carbon footprint transparent and available to all customers.

### Achieving the biggest impact

Otto Hofstetter AG is always mindful of its responsibilities to its customers, including in matters of sustainability. As a manufacturer, we have no influence on the emissions generated

during the use of our moulds. Thus, our reporting focuses on the direct and indirect emissions we cause (Scopes 1 to 3a in the CCF reporting scheme). These amount to approximately 6,100 tons of CO<sub>2</sub> equivalents. We found that the majority of emissions, around 50 percent, are attributable to the raw steel we use in the moulds. If the focus is limited to the carbon footprint produced from manufacturing to delivery ("cradle to gate") of the mould, this figure rises to around 95 percent. This is precisely where the greatest opportunity for reducing greenhouse gas emissions lies, and where customers can directly benefit.

### The switch to cleaner steel

In response to the new CCF report, Otto Hofstetter AG is gradually switching the two main types of steel it uses for its moulds, which account for more than 90 percent of the materials used. In future, we will use Climate+ steel, which is produced only with energy from renewable sources, such as wind and solar power, and also contains a higher proportion of recycled steel scrap.

The new steels will reduce the CO<sub>2</sub> footprint of the steel we use in our moulds by over 50 percent and will also lower the cradle-to-gate footprint of a mould by approximately 50 percent. For customers, this means they benefit from a reduced CO<sub>2</sub> footprint right from the start of mould commissioning. Upon request, the steel manufacturer will provide a product carbon footprint certificate for these grades.

### Same quality, same prices

Switching to Climate+ steels will not change the outstanding material properties of our moulds. Hardness, toughness, wear resistance and machinability all retain their high values, thus guaranteeing the dimensional stability and robustness of our moulds.

The result, for customers and for Otto Hofstetter AG, is a significantly reduced CO<sub>2</sub> footprint for new moulds, without requiring any adjustments to the design, operation or manufacturing processes, and with no increase in prices. Moulds from Otto Hofstetter AG will continue to deliver the same high standards of quality and performance that have been valued by our customers for over 70 years.

A man with short brown hair and black-rimmed glasses is smiling at the camera. He is wearing a black t-shirt with the word 'CROSSFIT' printed on the left chest. He has his arms crossed and is standing in what appears to be a workshop or factory setting, with industrial equipment and a bright light source visible in the background.

# Precision runs in his veins.

Enzo Helbling completed his apprenticeship as a polymechanic at Otto Hofstetter AG. Since then, he has remained loyal to the company. Today, he works as Deputy Head of the Soft Machining Department. In this interview, he explains why precision fascinates him and how he progressed from apprentice to his current leadership position. He also reveals what his hobby, Crossfit, has to do with discipline and why he values Rapperswil as his home.

**Enzo, in the summer of 2016, you began your apprenticeship as a polymechanic at Otto Hofstetter AG. What motivated you to choose this career path?**

I've always enjoyed working with my hands. When I was in secondary school, my father and I restored a motorcycle. Since then, I've been captivated by technology. I completed three different trial apprenticeships to find out which discipline suited me best. The decisive factor for me was that precision had to be central to the work, which is why I chose polymechanics. I saw that this profession fulfilled all my interests.

**To what extent did your perception of the profession match reality?**

During the short trial apprenticeship, you get a good impression of the work, although you hardly have access to the world of CNC machining in that time. That only came into play in the third and fourth years of the full apprenticeship, and it pleasantly surprised me. It's incredibly exciting to combine technology and mechanics with computer science. In the first two years, you still work largely conventionally, learning the basic metalworking skills like turning, milling and grinding. These manual skills are still important today and I believe they should always be part of a polymechanic's training. As the apprenticeship progresses, programming becomes ever more important. The individual parts become more complex, and the machines themselves more enclosed. Today, anyone who wants to become a polymechanic should also be enthusiastic about programming. This isn't a drawback of the profession, in my view, but rather an enhancement.

**Today you are the Deputy Head of the Soft Machining Department. What have you experienced on your way to that point?**

It happened surprisingly quickly. After my apprenticeship, I gained a year of practical experience working in production. Like many young men in Switzerland, I then had to do my military service. After basic training, I completed an advanced programme to become a sergeant. This is where I gained my first leadership experience. It was an intense time. Not always easy, but formative. When I returned to Otto Hofstetter AG after almost two years, I immersed myself in robotics and automation. My keen interest must have caught the attention of my superiors, and I was gradually given more responsibility. Eventually, I was asked if I would like to take on the role of

deputy department head. I was happy to accept, of course.

**What did you take from the military into your professional life?**

I learned to appreciate active and open communication. In the army, I always made sure to keep my team up-to-date and provided them with ample background information. Because if you understand the context of a task, you are more likely to complete it well. I now practice this active communication within my team as well. I don't just tell them what needs to be done, but also explain why.

**Everyone knew you as an apprentice. How did your colleagues react to your new role as a supervisor?**

We're a young team in the department and we respect each other. Therefore, my new role wasn't a problem for anyone. It's a give-and-take environment, where we help each other. I think a young team has an advantage in such situations: there are fewer entrenched structures that first need to be overcome.

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Enzo Helbling, Deputy Head of the Soft Machining Department

**What fascinates you most about working with computer-controlled machines?**

The possibilities with these tools are virtually endless. You can approach a task in many ways and still reach the desired goal. What you make of it depends on your own knowledge and expertise. No computer can do that, and that's what makes the work interesting every single day. Our metalworking machines do have some AI elements built in, such as a thermal imaging system that automatically corrects temperature-dependent parameters in the summer. But how you fundamentally approach the machining of a component and which strategy you choose is still decided by a human.

**What tasks are most important in the daily organisation of your department?**

We have a weekly quota that we have to meet. While the machine's features allow it to plan some tasks itself, the selection of specific tools is my responsibility. Pre-programming is also very important. Once one job is finished, the next one must be ready to start without any downtime. My colleagues are each responsible for their own area. This makes the work independent and interesting for everyone. My job is to coordinate everything and to ensure that everything works together seamlessly.

### What constitutes good teamwork for you?

First and foremost, communication is key. We've just commissioned a new workstation and we're processing many orders for the first time. This requires defining which raw material, dimensions and processes are suitable. My colleagues come to me with their questions, which I greatly appreciate. Trust is very important to me. In our daily work, it often happens that someone programs an order and another person executes it. You have to be able to rely on your colleague having done their job carefully. In our team, everyone can operate all six CNC machines, and everyone is enthusiastic about their work. That's not something to take for granted.

### How does this sense of camaraderie develop, and how do you maintain it?

Many of us have known each other since our apprenticeships, which provides a solid foundation. We go out for lunch together on Fridays, and we always sit together during breaks and chat. These kinds of habits don't happen on command; they develop when you value and respect one another. Trust takes time. Once it's in place, a lot of things practically run themselves.

### Why is Otto Hofstetter AG an attractive employer for you?

Primarily because of the machinery we use. We have the latest

equipment, we use robotics, and we work with a modern data management system and a large tool library. You don't find that everywhere, and it makes the work even more appealing. When I hear about other companies, I realise that we're really at the forefront when it comes to technology. The working environment is equally important. For example, vacation planning works well, and you can structure your days yourself. We also offer team events like a ski day in winter. That kind of shared activity is invaluable.

### Precision dominates your professional life. Does that also show up in your private life?

Absolutely. For example, my apartment is always tidy. I'm also very organised when it comes to cooking – which I really enjoy. I've been living with my girlfriend for a while now. She's a figure skating coach. Her job requires her to have a very structured day and to plan and coordinate her time to an extraordinary degree. At home, she enjoys it when I take on a bit more of the organisational and tidying-up tasks, which is fine with me.

### You do Crossfit as a way to unwind. Why that in particular?

Completely switching off my brain for an hour, that's the key for me. When you're working on a machine that costs a million francs, you always have to be very focused. Crossfit allows me truly to switch off after work and simultaneously push my physical limits. The self-discipline required for that physical training also helps me in working life. The dynamic at the gym is also motivating. I used to train alone at the gym but when others are pushing themselves alongside me, I get more out of myself than I thought possible. We push each other. Since my girlfriend also does Crossfit, we participate in competitions together. We both have a lot of fun with that.

### How important is sport for your overall well-being?

It's very important to me. Sport gives me energy for everything else. When I get home after a workout, I'm exhausted, but satisfied. Plus, it helps me sleep better and think more clearly. And it teaches you to persevere. In sports, not everything works perfectly on the first go. And it's the same in professional life.

### You ski in the winter. What does skiing bring you?

I really enjoy the combination of speed, precision and the feeling of freedom in nature that I get from skiing. And enjoying a leisurely meal between runs makes a day on the slopes fulfilling. My family used to go on skiing holidays a lot and now I have continued this tradition with my girlfriend. Skiing is a hobby I want to pursue for as many years as possible.



## Enzo Helbling

He's 25 years old and is Deputy Head of the Soft Machining Department at Otto Hofstetter AG, where he began his four-year apprenticeship as a polyme-  
chanic in 2016. He will start further training this year to become a production manager, a course of study that leads to a Swiss federal professional certification. He lives in Rapperswil, participates regularly in Crossfit training and is a passionate skier and cook.



After an intense workday in production at Otto Hofstetter AG, Enzo Helbling likes to unwind with Crossfit training and explore his personal limits.

**You live in Rapperswil. What do you particularly appreciate about the town and the surrounding area?**

I really like the landscape, the picturesque old town and the lake. In the summer, I cycle to go swimming. I can quickly do my shopping, and find almost everything else I need. Uznach is just fifteen minutes away and Zurich isn't far either, if I need more than Rapperswil offers. I grew up in a village nearby and often drove to Rapperswil with my parents. All in all, I feel very comfortable in the town and its surroundings.

**What are your career plans?**

This year I'm starting further training to become a production manager, culminating in a Swiss federal professional certification. It lasts a year, with classes two evenings a week and all day on Saturday. Most of the classes are held online. This requires a lot of self-discipline, but I have plenty of that. After that, I'd like to find a position as a department head. My wish is to continue my professional development at Otto Hofstetter

AG, as the company not only enables such development but also actively promotes it.

**"WITH US, YOU UNDERSTAND WHY PRECISION IS IMPORTANT. YOU LEARN TO APPRECIATE QUALITY STANDARDS, NOT BECAUSE YOU HAVE TO, BUT BECAUSE IT MAKES SENSE."**

Enzo Helbling, Deputy Head of the Soft Machining Department

**What advice would you give to young people considering an apprenticeship at Otto Hofstetter AG?**

Anyone interested in technology and who enjoys working with their hands will find exactly what they're looking for here. Here, you learn the profession of polymechanic from the ground up, not just a part

of it. Furthermore, you work on real customer orders right from the start. This is a significant difference compared to companies where apprentices spend four years doing practice work and then have some catching up to do. With us, you understand why precision is important. You learn to appreciate quality standards, not because you have to, but because it makes sense.

**Enzo Helbling, thank you very much for the interview.**

# Light reveals traditional Swiss craftsmanship.



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